Declaration of Sentiments

Seneca Falls Convention · July 19–20, 1848 · principal author: Elizabeth Cady Stanton

Source: Declaration of Sentiments (Seneca Falls, 1848), as printed in Stanton, Anthony & Gage, History of Woman Suffrage, vol. I (1881), text via Project Gutenberg (#28020). Public domain.

The Seneca Falls Convention in upstate New York is conventionally called the start of the organized American women's-rights movement. Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott drafted the Declaration of Sentiments by deliberately rewriting the Declaration of Independence — substituting 'all men' with 'all men and women' and replacing the king's grievances with a list of injustices women suffered under men's law. About 300 people attended; 100 signed.

Connect: How did the Erie Canal (1825, Class 8 era) set up the Northern industrial economy you're reading about now?

Key Passages

Preamble (rewritten)

> We hold these truths to be self-evident: that all men and women are created equal; that they are endowed by their Creator with certain inalienable rights; that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness; that to secure these rights governments are instituted, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed.

Sample grievances

> He has never permitted her to exercise her inalienable right to the elective franchise. He has compelled her to submit to laws, in the formation of which she had no voice. He has withheld from her rights which are given to the most ignorant and degraded men—both natives and foreigners.

Resolution on suffrage (carried narrowly, with Frederick Douglass's support)

> Resolved, That it is the duty of the women of this country to secure to themselves their sacred right to the elective franchise.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The antebellum reform era and the Second Great Awakening; women active in abolition were often barred from speaking, and married women had few legal rights.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Those at the Seneca Falls Convention and the broader American public, including lawmakers, newspapers, and fellow reformers.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Middle-class white women reformers led by Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott; the concerns of working-class and enslaved Black women are largely missing.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Evidence (1 pt): Use this document plus ONE other reform-era source to argue that antebellum reform movements were interconnected.
2. Why did Stanton structure the document as a parody of the Declaration of Independence?
3. What does the narrow passage of the suffrage resolution suggest about reform politics in 1848?

The Declaration of Sentiments

Elizabeth Cady Stanton & the Seneca Falls Convention · 1848

Source: Declaration of Sentiments (Seneca Falls, 1848), as printed in Stanton, Anthony & Gage, History of Woman Suffrage, vol. I (1881), text via Project Gutenberg (#28020). Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> Modeled directly on the Declaration of Independence, this document launched the organized women's rights movement, listing women's grievances and demanding equal rights — "that all men and women are created equal."

Preamble (rewritten)

When, in the course of human events, it becomes necessary for one portion of the family of man to assume among the people of the earth a position different from that which they have hitherto occupied, but one to which the laws of nature and of nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes that impel them to such a course.

We hold these truths to be self-evident: that all men and women are created equal; that they are endowed by their Creator with certain inalienable rights; that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness; that to secure these rights governments are instituted, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed. . . . But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute despotism, it is their duty to throw off such government, and to provide new guards for their future security. Such has been the patient sufferance of the women under this government, and such is now the necessity which constrains them to demand the equal station to which they are entitled.

Grievances

The history of mankind is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations on the part of man toward woman, having in direct object the establishment of an absolute tyranny over her. To prove this, let facts be submitted to a candid world.

He has never permitted her to exercise her inalienable right to the elective franchise. He has compelled her to submit to laws, in the formation of which she had no voice. He has withheld from her rights which are given to the most ignorant and degraded men—both natives and foreigners. . . . He has made her, if married, in the eye of the law, civilly dead. He has taken from her all right in property, even to the wages she earns. . . . In the covenant of marriage, she is compelled to promise obedience to her husband, he becoming, to all intents and purposes, her master—the law giving him power to deprive her of her liberty, and to administer chastisement. . . . He has monopolized nearly all the profitable employments, and from those she is permitted to follow, she receives but a scanty remuneration. He closes against her all the avenues to wealth and distinction which he considers most honorable to himself. As a teacher of theology, medicine, or law, she is not known.

He has denied her the facilities for obtaining a thorough education, all colleges being closed against her.

He allows her in Church, as well as State, but a subordinate position, claiming Apostolic authority for her exclusion from the ministry, and, with some exceptions, from any public participation in the affairs of the Church. . . . He has endeavored, in every way that he could, to destroy her confidence in her own powers, to lessen her self-respect, and to make her willing to lead a dependent and abject life.

Demand and plan of action

Now, in view of this entire disfranchisement of one-half the people of this country, their social and religious degradation—in view of the unjust laws above mentioned, and because women do feel themselves aggrieved, oppressed, and fraudulently deprived of their most sacred rights, we insist that they have immediate admission to all the rights and privileges which belong to them as citizens of the United States.

In entering upon the great work before us, we anticipate no small amount of misconception, misrepresentation, and ridicule; but we shall use every instrumentality within our power to effect our object. We shall employ agents, circulate tracts, petition the State and National legislatures, and endeavor to enlist the pulpit and the press in our behalf. We hope this Convention will be followed by a series of Conventions embracing every part of the country.

[. . .]

Resolution on suffrage

Resolved, That it is the duty of the women of this country to secure to themselves their sacred right to the elective franchise.

[. . .]

Editors' note (History of Woman Suffrage, vol. I)

The only resolution that was not unanimously adopted was the ninth, urging the women of the country to secure to themselves the elective franchise. Those who took part in the debate feared a demand for the right to vote would defeat others they deemed more rational, and make the whole movement ridiculous.

Words to know

inalienable rights — rights that cannot be taken away or given up

usurpations — wrongful seizures of power or rights

elective franchise — the right to vote

civilly dead — having no legal existence or rights of one's own under the law

chastisement — physical punishment

remuneration — pay for work

disfranchisement — denial of the right to vote

tracts — short printed pamphlets arguing a cause